

What the future holds

AI and other emerging technologies, apart from bringing efficiencies, are also bringing new possibilities. These possibilities are creating new business models and opportunities. This will continue to happen in the future as we progress.

Most daily tasks that depend on best estimates or guesswork would also see a significant shift due to abundance of data. Due to access to more data, the need for devices that can process this data on Edge would increase and will be a key driver in maintaining this progression.

One of the significant drivers of these technological advances is democratisation of resources. Whether it is the Internet revolution, open source hardware and software revolution, or anything else, as AI technology becomes a part of our daily lives, we will see more of this democratisation happening. This will be a crucial factor and will keep boosting progress.

As of now, most AI applications follow a supervised learning approach. In years to come, we will start seeing more and more of unsupervised learning that will keep systems updated continuously. However, this will have one significant barrier to cross, which is the trust factor. Unless this trust factor improves, supervision will remain a necessity.

There is no accepted or standard definition of good AI. However, good AI is one that can guide users understand various options, explain tradeoffs among multiple possible choices and then help make those decisions. Good AI will always honour the final decision made by humans.

On the consumer front, several virtual support tools would increase and become mainstream. It will be almost expected to come across these bots first before talking to any human at all. However, only businesses that demonstrate a customer-centric approach would thrive in these scenarios, while others would struggle

to adapt to the right technology. And, most importantly, “What do you want to do when you grow up?” will soon become an obsolete question.

AI will change the job market entirely as there will be growing requirements for soft skills, since most hard skills will be automated. Especially for the Indian economy, since we have mostly relied on hard skills for local as well as global opportunities, this will pose a significant challenge to keep up with declining demands. We will be forced to come up with new business models, not just as businesses but also as an economy.

Maintaining a balanced approach

Regardless of how the recent or long-term future with AI looks like, there are a few points that we must understand and accept in entirety. Most of these points align with OECD’s AI principles that were released in early 2019.

AI systems should benefit humans, the overall ecosystem on the planet, and the planet itself by driving inclusive growth, sustainable development and well-being of all. These systems must always be designed such that they respect and follow the rule of law and rights of the ecosystem (humans, animals, etc). These should also respect the general human value system and the diversity it exhibits. More importantly, there must be appropriate safeguards in the system such that humans are always in the loop when necessary, or can intervene if they feel the need, regardless of necessity. After all, a fair and just society should be the goal of any advancement.

Creators of AI systems should always demonstrate transparency

and responsible disclosure about the functionality and methodology of the system. People involved and affected by this need to understand how outcomes are derived and, if required, should be able to challenge them.

Any AI system should not cause harm to users or general living beings, and must always function in a robust, secure and safe way throughout its lifecycle. Creators and managers of these systems have the responsibility to assess continually and manage any risks in this regard.

Most importantly, on the accountability front, anyone creating, developing, deploying, operating or managing AI systems must always be held accountable for the system’s functioning and outcomes. Accountability can drive positive behaviours and thereby potentially ensure that all the above general principles have been adhered to.

There is a general feeling that over-regulation limits innovation and advancements. However, there is no point in racing to be the first; instead, let us strive to be better. Being fast and first by compromising on ethics and quality is certainly not an acceptable approach by any means.

It is unlikely that in the next ten years or so, we will have robots controlling humans. However, technology consuming us, our time, feelings and mindfulness is very much a reality even today; and it is getting worse day by day already.

Just one wrong turn in this fast lane is what it will take to cause regression for society. The rise of AI should not lead to the fall of humanity. Let us work towards keeping the technology, AI or otherwise, in our control, always! 

 By: Anand Tamboli

The author is a serial entrepreneur, speaker, award-winning published author and emerging technology thought leader.

The article was originally published in the February 2020 issue of Electronics For You.